

SEO Sales Pitch Playbook

How to explain SEO to a client.

Sales training pitch reference · Marketing Sweet · May 2026

1. The librarian metaphor

Customers don't know what SEO is. They know what a library is. This metaphor reframes the entire conversation in the first three minutes — and gives them a mental model that holds for everything that follows.

Three pieces:

- Google is the librarian. It has every book in the world and decides which ones get put on the shelf where the customer looks.
- Your website is a book. One of millions. Title, author, table of contents, references. Either useful — or invisible.
- Our job is to get your book shelved at eye-level. Everything else is a tactic underneath that.

Use this script in the first three minutes of the pitch, in your own words:

“Think of Google as a librarian. There are millions of websites — millions of books on the shelf. When someone searches for what you sell, the librarian decides which books to put at eye-level and which to leave in the back room. SEO is the work we do to convince the librarian that your book belongs at eye-level. We do that across four categories: what your book says, what other authors say about you, whether your book actually opens cleanly, and whether you're the local expert on the topic. Make sense?”

2. The four categories of SEO

Every product we sell sits in one of these four boxes. If a rep can't name all four without thinking, they're not ready to quote SEO.

- On-page — what's inside the book. Words, headings, structure, internal links. The content the librarian actually reads.
- Off-page — what other authors say about you. Backlinks, citations, mentions. Reputation built on other people's websites pointing to yours.
- Technical — whether the book opens cleanly. Speed, mobile, indexing, schema, crawl health. Plumbing the librarian uses to read the book at all.
- Local — whether you're the local expert. Google Business Profile, reviews, map listings, NAP consistency. The librarian's local section.

RULE OF THUMB Always name the four. Always in the same order. On-page, off-page, technical, local.

3. What each category actually is

Use this when the customer asks “but what do you actually do?” The answer is never “SEO stuff.”

CATEGORY	WHAT WE DO	WHAT THEY SEE	WHY IT MATTERS
On-page	Rewrite page titles, headings, body copy, internal links. Add schema. Build topic clusters.	Their pages read like they belong to someone who knows the topic.	The librarian reads the book before recommending it.
Off-page	Earn backlinks from relevant, high-authority sites. Outreach, digital PR, content placements.	Other websites — ideally well-known ones — start mentioning theirs.	Authors with more references get shelved at eye-level.
Technical	Fix speed, mobile usability, crawl errors, broken links, sitemaps, schema, indexing issues.	The site loads fast, works on mobile, doesn't break.	If the librarian can't open the book, none of the content matters.
Local	Optimise Google Business Profile, build reviews, fix NAP consistency, add local landing pages.	They appear in the map pack when someone searches "near me."	60% of local searches happen on the map. Win the map or be invisible.

4. Product → category map

Before you quote, you should be able to point to the row on this map and say which category you're solving for. If you can't, the customer can't either — and the deal will stall on price.

PRODUCT	PRIMARY CATEGORY	ALSO TOUCHES	WHAT TO SAY
SEO content packages	On-page	Local (location pages)	"We rewrite your book."
Backlink campaigns	Off-page	On-page (anchor strategy)	"We get other authors to cite you."
Site audits & fixes	Technical	On-page (structure)	"We make sure the book opens cleanly."
Google Business setup	Local	Off-page (citations)	"We get you on the local shelf."
Review generation	Local	Off-page (reputation)	"We feed the librarian social proof."
Monthly SEO retainers	All four	Reporting + strategy	"We work all four every month."

5. Domain Authority = author credibility

DA is not a vanity score. It's the librarian's read on how much weight your book carries — measured. Customers see the number and think it's about them. Reframe it as the author's reputation.

"If two authors wrote a book on the same topic, the librarian recommends the one with the better reputation. Domain Authority is that reputation — measured. The higher your DA, the more weight your pages carry, and the easier every other piece of SEO becomes."

Three rules for using DA in a pitch:

1. Show the customer's DA and three competitors' DAs. Numbers beat opinions every time.
2. Never promise to "raise DA by X." Promise the work that does it.
3. Frame backlink work as "getting other authors to cite your book."

6. Pitch watch-outs

Avoid the habits that quietly kill an SEO pitch:

- Don't explain SEO from scratch on every call — open with the librarian metaphor.
- Don't use jargon: keywords, SERPs, algorithms, indexation. Stay in books, authors, shelves.
- Don't quote a product without naming the category it lives in.
- Don't promise DA increases. Promise the work.
- Don't dive into category 1 if the gap is in category 3 — diagnose first.
- Don't apologise for the price. The price reflects the work, and the work is in all four categories.
- Don't skip the metaphor with "technical" customers. They like it more than anyone.
- Don't forget local. It's half the deals.

THE ONE-LINER "Google is a librarian. Websites are books. Our job is to make sure the librarian shelves your book at eye-level." If you can say that out loud, you can sell SEO.